

“The three immediate differences that come to mind are scope, resources and community,” says Shah. While corporates most likely restrict the areas of innovation to their specific domain or industry, a makerspace is a zone of unhindered innovation. “Sometimes, there need not even be a business motive for a makerspace project. Business drives innovation labs at corporates, passion drives projects at a makerspace,” he adds.

With regard to resources, corporates, once committed to innovation, are willing to pump in any amount of resources required to realise ideas. On the other hand (and sometimes as a plus point), makerspaces globally thrive on limited resources in terms of tools, technology, space, etc. Does this frugal approach aid innovative thinking? Perhaps, is Shah’s answer.

“The biggest difference, and the decider that turns the needle towards makerspaces is the power of communities that it creates. Having the most creative minds across diverse disciplines willing to contribute and collaborate voluntarily on ideas is an asset that is extremely difficult to create within a corporate organisation. Often, it is only when the motivation to make and build is non-monetary that the best ideas can come alive,” says Shah.

For individual makers, the fact that consumers were willing to pay a premium for products that were intelligent and artisanal all at once, helped.

Relationships were built on the basis of this; zero to maker, maker to maker and maker to market. Makerspaces functioned like makeshift co-working spaces where the same sense of community prevailed; artistes collaborated with techies who worked with handymen. Fab Labs and for-profit ventures like TechShop that followed a similar working principle also gave makers a physical address. Startups that were driven by hardware or physical goods found an avenue to prototype at a lower cost and churn out a final product that was on par in terms of quality when compared to corporate offerings and at a fraction of the cost. They were also able to tap into their free-loving community of designers, product strategists and marketing professionals that formed the ecosystem.

Emerging platforms like Thingiverse, Instructables and Make-zine made it possible to share knowledge and designs with the niche community, and Autocad and Sketchup provided easy-to-use software for the designer community to work in tandem with innovators while using 3D printers. Cubify, Shapeways and Ponoko set up platforms for designers to share their designs so users could pay to download and print them elsewhere in the world.

Makers connected to other makers to develop kits that could cut down the running around and rigmarole of finding and fitting electronic components